

69 Uriah the Hittite

A foreign-born soldier who kept faith with Israel's army while Israel's king broke faith with him.

Uriah was a Hittite of foreign descent, yet he was listed among David's mighty men. His name means "the LORD is my light," probably a sign that he or his family worshipped Israel's God. While Uriah was fighting for David at Rabbah, David took his wife, Bathsheba. To hide it, the king called Uriah home and urged him to go to his house. Uriah refused comforts his fellow soldiers could not have. So David sent him back to the front carrying his own death warrant. Uriah's quiet integrity shines against the king's scheming, and Scripture never forgets it.

At a glance

Name	Hebrew <i>Uriyah</i> , "the LORD is my light"
People	A Hittite, in Canaan since Abraham's day (Genesis 23:10)
Wife	Bathsheba, daughter of Eliam (2 Samuel 11:3)
Rank	One of David's mighty men (2 Samuel 23:39)
When	Middle of David's reign, during the Ammonite war (rough)
Key people	David, Bathsheba, Joab
New Testament	Matthew 1:6, as "Urias"

"Because David did that which was right in the eyes of the LORD, and turned not aside from any thing that he commanded him all the days of his life, save only in the matter of Uriah the Hittite."

1 Kings 15:5, KJV

The life of Uriah the Hittite

Scripture gives no dates or ages for Uriah. These events fall in the middle of David's reign (c. 1010–970 BC), during the war with Ammon.

Earlier	● A mighty man Uriah the Hittite is listed among David's mighty men, his most honored warriors. He is married to Bathsheba, and his house in Jerusalem is within view of the palace roof. <i>2 Samuel 23:39; 11:2–3, 8</i>
Spring	● At war "At the time when kings go forth to battle," David sends Joab and the army to besiege Rabbah. Uriah goes with them, while David stays in Jerusalem. <i>2 Samuel 11:1</i>
Called home	● Refuses his comforts David calls Uriah back, asks about the war, and tells him to go home. Uriah sleeps at the palace door instead. The next night David gets him drunk, but he still will not go home. <i>2 Samuel 11:6–13</i>
The letter	● Carries his own death warrant David writes to Joab: put Uriah where the battle is hottest, then pull back from him. Uriah carries the sealed letter back to the camp himself. <i>2 Samuel 11:14–15</i>
At Rabbah	● Killed in battle Joab sends Uriah near the city wall. Some of David's soldiers fall, and "Uriah the Hittite died also." Joab sends word to David. <i>2 Samuel 11:16–25</i>

Group notes

Key activities

David's mighty men were a band of his best warriors, many of whom had been with him since his days as a fugitive. Uriah is the last name on the list in 2 Samuel 23, which ends, "Uriah the Hittite: thirty and seven in all."

- 1 **Served a foreign king faithfully.** Though a Hittite by descent, he fought among David's best soldiers. *2 Samuel 23:39; 1 Chronicles 11:41*
- 2 **Stood with his comrades.** He slept at the king's door, saying he would not go home to eat, drink and be with his wife while the ark and the army were in tents. *2 Samuel 11:9-11*
- 3 **Kept his word.** He swore, "as thou livest, and as thy soul liveth, I will not do this thing." *2 Samuel 11:11*
- 4 **Held firm when drunk.** Even when David made him drunk, he did not go down to his house. *2 Samuel 11:13*
- 5 **Obedied the king to the end.** He carried David's letter to Joab and went where he was sent. *2 Samuel 11:14-17*

Group notes

This image shows a single sheet of white paper with horizontal blue or grey ruling lines, typical of notebook paper. The lines are evenly spaced and run across the width of the page. There is no handwriting or other markings on the paper.

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Uriah.

Old Testament

2 Samuel 11	The main account
2 Samuel 12:9–10	Nathan: "thou hast killed Uriah the Hittite with the sword"
2 Samuel 23:39; 1 Chronicles 11:41	Listed among David's mighty men
1 Kings 15:5	David right "save only in the matter of Uriah"
Echo: Proverbs 28:6	The poor who walk uprightly are better than the perverse

New Testament

Matthew 1:6	Matthew keeps "Urias" in the family line of Jesus
Echo: 2 Timothy 2:3–4	A soldier of Christ endures hardness

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What reasons did Uriah give for not going home (2 Samuel 11:11)?
2. *Understand:* Why do you think the writer lets Uriah, a foreigner, show more integrity than the king of Israel?
3. *Apply:* Uriah refused comforts his friends did not have. Where could you stand with people who are going through a hard time?
4. *Apply:* Uriah's goodness is remembered in Scripture even though he was wronged. When have you had to keep doing right while someone treated you unfairly?